

Chapter 2: National and Regional Trends and Forecasts

Population, Household, and Employment Trends

Historical population and household trends from 1990 to 2020 were analyzed using decennial census block-level data obtained from the Integrated Public Use Microdata Series (IPUMS) National Historical Geographic Information System (NHGS). Employment trends for the Tri-Cities region were estimated using county-level annual averages from the Bureau of Labor Statistics (BLS) Quarterly Census of Employment and Wages (QCEW) during the same period. Population and employment growth supports economic development. It also directly affects travel demand, leading to increased congestion, emissions, and greater crash frequency due to higher traffic volumes. These factors indicate that as a region grows, there is a clear need for higher investment in a robust multimodal transportation system, including pedestrian and bicycle safety improvements, increased transit accessibility, and reductions in highway congestion, as well greater destination access for all modes of transportation.

As shown in **Figure 6**, the population of the Tri-Cities region grew steadily between 1990 and 2020, increasing by 24.4 percent from 134,954 to 167,920. Over the same period, population growth in both Virginia and the United States outpaced that of the region, with Virginia's population increasing by 39.5 percent and the nation's population increasing by 33.3 percent.

Figure 6. Regional, State, and National Population Growth by Decade, 1990-2020

Source: IPUMS National Historical Geographic Information System

Figure 7 illustrates that population growth has been uneven across the six jurisdictions and the three decennial periods between 1990 and 2020. During this period, the region's largest population growth has occurred in counties dominated by suburban and rural areas. The TCAMPO portion of Chesterfield County grew by 69.3 percent between 1990 and 2020, experiencing the largest decennial increases between 1990-2000 and 2000-2010. The TCAMPO portion of Dinwiddie County also experienced strong growth, increasing by 58.3 percent over the same period, although growth slowed considerably after 2010. The TCAMPO portion of Prince George County grew by approximately 56 percent between 1990 and 2020, with its largest increase occurring between 2010 and 2020. Colonial Heights experienced steady population growth in each decade between 1990 and 2020 resulting in a 13.1 percent overall increase. In contrast, Petersburg experienced a 12.8 percent population decline between 1990 and 2020, with a 3 percent increase since 2010. During this period, Hopewell's population remained stable with only a 0.3 percent decline between 1990 and 2020, although its population has slightly recovered in the last two decennial periods.

Figure 7. TCAMPO Population Growth by Jurisdiction and Decade, 1990-2020

Source: IPUMS National Historical Geographic Information System

Figure 8 shows that the number of households in the region grew by 28.4 percent between 1990 and 2020, increasing from 48,586 to 62,362. Like population growth during this same period, households grew at a slower rate than both Virginia (44.9 percent) and the nation as a whole (37.9 percent). Furthermore, this growth was not evenly distributed among the region's jurisdictions studied in this analysis. Chesterfield County experienced the highest growth (74.2 percent), followed by Dinwiddie County (61.1 percent) and Prince George County (46.9 percent). In contrast, household growth was positive, but substantially less in Colonial Heights (20.0 percent), Hopewell (4.2 percent), and Petersburg (4.4 percent). The latter two are notable given that Petersburg's and Hopewell's population actually declined over this same period.

The relationship between population and household growth rates is reflected in changes in household size. Across all jurisdictions, average household size declined by 3.1 percent from 2.8 to 2.7 people per household between 1990 and 2020. This reduction is consistent with broader demographic trends toward smaller households across the Commonwealth (minus 3.7 percent) and the United States (minus 3.4 percent). Within the region, household size decreased in all jurisdictions except Prince George, where it increased from 3.4 to 3.6 people per household. In contrast, Petersburg experienced the largest decline, falling by 16.5 percent from 2.6 to 2.2 people per household.

Figure 8. Regional, State, and National Household Growth by Decade, 1990-2020

Source: IPUMS National Historical Geographic Information System

As with population growth, **Figure 9** illustrates that household growth varied significantly by jurisdiction and decennial period. In Chesterfield, Dinwiddie, Prince George, and Colonial Heights, household growth was strongest between 1990 and 2000. Hopewell and Petersburg followed the opposite pattern, with both cities recording their fastest household growth between 2010 and 2020. After losing households throughout the 1990s and 2000s, Petersburg had the highest household growth rate of any TCAMPO jurisdiction between 2010 and 2020, even as its population growth remained the second lowest in the region. This discrepancy suggests that much of Petersburg's new housing stock was absorbed by smaller households.

Figure 9. TCAMPO Household Growth by Jurisdiction and Decade, 1990-2020

Source: IPUMS National Historical Geographic Information System

Because the earliest available year for LEHD data is 2002, historical block-level employment data is not available for this analysis. Therefore, QCEW county-level annual averages were proportionally allocated to the Tri-Cities boundaries using area weighted interpolation based on block-level total employment in the 2023 LODES WAC dataset. **Figure 10** shows that employment in the Tri-Cities region has increased by about 47.3 percent from 37,198 in 1990 to 54,780 in 2020. In contrast with population and households, employment is growing at a faster rate than the state (32.3%) and the country (28.1%). Employment growth was comparatively slower between 2000 and 2010, reflecting the impacts of the Great Recession and broader economic conditions that reduced job growth during that period.

Figure 10. Regional, State, and National Employment Growth by Decade, 1990-2020

Source: Bureau of Labor Statistics QCEW County-Level Annual Averages